For India, its enduring friendly relations with Russia had gradually been becoming more complicated. Strategic Russian technologies such as defence, nuclear, and space remained very important for India, but had not always been accompanied by technology transfers. Still, Russia remained open to, for example, leasing nuclear-powered attack submarines to India, something that the United States and its allies were still unwilling to countenance. Although India was not a major importer of Russian oil and gas, it had investments in oil and coal infrastructures, especially in Russia's far east. But beyond these considerations, trade and people-to-people contacts between India and Russia had withered and active Indian efforts at broadening the commercial relationship proved frustrating. By contrast, New Delhi's ties with Europe had begun to take on greater priority, encompassing trade, technology, counterterrorism, labour mobility, and defence.

But the war in Ukraine had several immediate consequences. India had been one of only three foreign destinations for Putin since the outbreak of the pandemic (the other being to Geneva to meet US President Joe Biden and to Beijing just weeks before initiating the Ukraine War). Even in late 2021, he gave little hint of his intentions to New Delhi. [47] Once war broke out, India's immediate priority was the evacuation of over 20,000 Indian citizens from Ukraine, including numerous university students. The evacuations from Kharkhiv and Sumy proved particularly complicated, requiring delicate Indian negotiations with both Moscow and Kyiv.

India had four other immediate concerns. One, it had to secure a continuing supply of Russian defence equipment, maintenance, and spares, particularly given urgent requirements on the LAC with China. Two, India required energy as Europe and the United States placed sanctions on Russian oil and gas, and Europe began to source more from the Middle East, which had been India's biggest traditional supplier. Although Russian oil had traditionally been too expensive for India, it was now price competitive, and large-scale imports were required to stabilize domestic and international prices. A third concern was food security, particularly grain shipments from Ukraine and Russia, as well as fertilizers. Finally, India